

80-year-old Nemo remembers 'kids'

By RICHARD LUNA
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There is one little man who stands tall in Texas high school athletics. His real name is William Carson Herrera, but he is better known as Nemo.

Nemo Herrera is a small man, standing only 5-foot-5. But he may be 5-foot-5 all heart.

And ageless? Herrera turned a young 80 this February and has vivid memories of the 43 years he spent coaching in Texas, especially the 14 years in El Paso.

There's one year in particular — 1949 — when he coached the Bowie Bears to El Paso's only state high school baseball championship.

"I don't have any regrets," said Herrera, who now resides in San Antonio. "I did my best. And that's all I wanted my kids to do — give their best."

Herrera still calls them his — and some of his kids are now into their 60s.

"I remember all my boys and I still get letters from them all the time. Yes sir, I was lucky to work some good kids in El Paso."

Herrera was born in Brownsville but grew up in San Antonio, where he played basketball and baseball at Brackenridge High School (now San Antonio Wheatley High); he was part of the first class ever in the school. He went on to Southwestern University in Georgetown in the fall of 1918 and, by the time he finished in 1922, he had earned four letters in



NEMO HERRERA
... A hero around Bowie High

basketball (besides scoring more points than all other players combined) and in baseball.

He then "fooled around a couple of years playing semi-pro baseball with the Galveston Sandcrabs in the Texas League."

In the fall of 1923, he took over as basketball coach at Beaumont High School, where his team went 19-1.

"But I didn't want to stay in coaching," Herrera said. "So, I went to Tampico (Mexico) to work with Gulf Refining, and I played baseball there

until 1928 when I went back to San Antonio."

Herrera began coaching that year at San Antonio Lanier High School and stayed there until 1945. In all, his teams won two state basketball championships (1943 and 1945), were runnersup in 1939 and finished third in 1942 and 1944. His teams at one time went to the state tournament seven straight years.

Then came the move out West.

"I had heard a lot about dear old El Paso," Herrera said. "I remember hearing about a kid named Andy Cohen at El Paso High in the '20s."

That kid Cohen is now 75 and played on El Paso High's 1921 state championship basketball team. He later played professional baseball with the New York Giants and also coached baseball at UTEP. Last year, Cohen was the first base coach for the El Paso Diablos.

"I was umpiring in the Mexican League in the summer of 45 when Mr. Hughey (school superintendent A.H. Hughey) told me he had a job for me. I told him that I already had a job, and then he said he had a better one for me."

At first, Herrera turned down the job because he loved San Antonio and Hughey wouldn't pay Herrera's moving expenses from San Antonio.

"That's all I really wanted," Herrera said. "And Hughey later said he would take care of everything, so I went to Bowie in 1945 as head basketball and baseball coach."

"I got right in there and told the boys at Bowie exactly what I expected. They were the same class of kids that I had at Lanier — the poorer Mexican boys. But they were hungry to win so I wasn't surprised when we went to the state baseball tournament in 1949."

"Yes sir, that was a real highlight," Herrera said. "Well, I tell you, I had the material. Ruben Porras and Trini Guillen were two of the best pitchers that I ever worked with. I had a good rounded ballclub at every position."

At the state tournament, Porras pitched the first game, Guillen the second game and then Porras pitched in the finals, where the Bears edged Austin (of Austin) 3-2.

"Everybody really looked at us down there (in Austin) because they knew we had something to show them," Herrera said. "My boys were excited the whole time and, oh God, especially after we won. On the way back to El Paso, some fans met us in Fabens and we had a parade back into town."

But Herrera didn't have winning teams just in baseball. In 1948, Bowie finished fourth at the state basketball tournament and lost out in the first round of the 1949 tourney. He stayed at Bowie until 1962, when a new school on El Paso's Westside — Coronado — opened and Herrera was reassigned. "We started out just with ninth graders at Coronado," Herrera said. "I remember that was the first time

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